

Exploring health outcomes and care experiences of adults with post-COVID-19 condition in Belgium

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Background

Post-COVID-19 condition (PCC) and its multisystemic effects have a profound impact on health systems. Important to gain more insight into PCC patients' perspectives, perceived health outcomes and care experiences in Belgium

Methods

- OECD's Patient-Reported Indicator Surveys (PaRIS)
 - patient-reported outcomes (PROMs)
 - patient-reported experience measures (PREMs)
- Self-reported data (collected during March 2023-January 2024) from 4687 primary care patients (aged 45+; 80% with chronic conditions, 20% without)
- Comparing PROMs and PREMs of adults with and without PCC
- Mixed-effects models (linear or logistic, adjusted for age and sex) and heatmaps for 10 key indicators (PaRIS10) were constructed

Results

- 50% (N=2359) had a previous COVID-19 diagnosis
- 26% (N=605) report persistent (>=2 months) PCC-related symptoms (12.9% overall prevalence)
- Higher risk of PCC was associated with being female, aged 45-54, having multiple chronic conditions, higher BMI, and lower education

Post-COVID-19 condition (PCC)	Patient-reported outcome measures (PROMs)					Patient-reported experience measures (PREMs)				
	General health (%)	Well-being (/100)	Physical health (16.2-67.7)	Mental health (21.2-67.6)	Social functioning (%)	Experienced quality of care (%)	Confidence to self-manage (%)	Trust in healthcare system (%)	Experienced coordination (/15)	Person-centred care (/24)
Positive Outcomes	Good, very good, excellent	≥ 50	≥ 42	≥ 40	Good, very good, excellent	Good, very good, excellent	Confident, very confident	Agree, strongly agree	≥ 7.5	≥ 12.0
NO PCC (n = 1588)	81.7	64.5	48.3	47.9	90.6	96.8	69.5	73.7	9.27	18.3
PCC (n = 605)	71.3*	56.5*	43.9*	45.7*	86.1	96.1	64	64.6	8.69	17.4
PCC, symptoms lasted between 2 months - 1 year (n = 487)	72.6	57.2*	44.2*	45.5*	86.3	95.8	62.5	66	8.71	17.4
PCC, symptoms lasted at least 1 year (n = 118)	65.7*	53.6*	42.8*	46.4	85.1	97.1	69.9	58.8	8.59	17.2
PCC, long-term symptoms during survey time (n = 165)	60.2*	50.2*	40.7*	45.4*	82.4	95.3	63	57.2*	8.29	16.5*

* value differs significantly (p<0.05) from the reference (No PCC)
Results are adjusted for age, sex & number of chronic conditions, taking into account the hierarchical structure of the data. Data is weighted using STATBEL 2023 >= 45 years old

Keywords
patient-reported indicators
post-COVID-19 condition – primary care

Conclusion

In Belgium, adult patients in primary care with PCC report poorer health outcomes and less positive care experiences compared to those without PCC.

Patient-reported indicators show substantial differences in care between PCC and non-PCC patients in Belgium, underscoring the importance of adequate follow-up and support by healthcare professionals.